

Now FB lets you forget

Facebook's "on this day" now allows you to filter out specific dates after it brought up bad memories <http://dgit.in/Nv15aa>

**Giphy on your browser**

The GIF creator service is now available on your web browser. Just put a video link, set start-end points and you're done! <http://dgit.in/Nv15an>



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Get started with APIs

So you can create websites but don't you wish you could expand your skills to combine different APIs to create something awesome? Let us help you



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Ever wonder what goes on behind the button that says "Sign up with Facebook" that logs you into any of your favorite websites without having to type a word? With just a few clicks, your favorite website automatically gets all your details. Or how about that travel website which fetches your travel dates from different airlines and presents you

with the available flights with their pricing. Obviously, there must be something that allows one website to access details from another website without jeopardising your security.

It's the magic of API, which stands for 'Application Programming Interface'. Consider API your personal assistant who brings you all the relevant information you need from other websites (that have an API) as per set conditions. So take a guess at what "conditions" would be set up behind the button "Sign up with Facebook"? Well, it depends on what details are required by the external website you're trying to log in to, however, things like your name and email address are usually conditions that would be set up. And then the external site sends an HTTP request (with access token for authentication) to Facebook's API. Facebook then asks you whether to provide the details or not. If you select "allow", the website obtains the required details and stores them in its own database.

This clearly minimises the need for repetition. Every time we register on a new website, we don't need to re-enter our name and email address (and at times, tons of other fields). After all, our personal details won't change from site to site. And since repetition is minimised, it saves our time.

APIs further enable third-party apps to improve user interaction. So, if you're sick of Candy Crush notifications, blame APIs - they're the reason why your friend 'x' constantly sends you game invites and requests. In this case, the Candy Crush application asked user 'x' to let Candy Crush control his notification and since user 'x' agreed, Candy Crush can now send any friend of user 'x' a notification whenever the app wants to.

An API is basically a mechanism that allows you to talk to other websites with the help of requests made over different protocols such as HTTP and SMTP. In fact, it's almost like opening any other web page on your browser. The only difference is that with APIs, you need to code the part played by the browser, i.e. sending requests over HTTP and getting the relevant data back.

SOAP and REST

APIs are further classified into two groups: 'SOAP' (Simple Object Access Protocol) and 'REST' (REpresentational State Transfer). Despite the fact that 'S' stands for 'simple' in SOAP, it isn't actually very 'simple' and this is because it's heavily dependent upon XML, and its responses and requests look way more cryptic than REST API's. Moreover, SOAP need not always use HTTP protocol and could be seen using FTP or SMTP also. However, it's better to start off with the REST API, because, after all, it's what most websites use and the better bet when you can't decide between REST and SOAP based APIs.

Earlier, when we talked about making HTTP requests, we were using the REST API. It accepts HTTP requests and generally returns a JSON (JavaScript Object Notation) formatted result, which is easy to work with and less cryptic than XML. Before you



dive into sending the HTTP request from your own website, let's take a quick look at what GET and POST method means and how you can experiment with them.

Understanding GET and POST

A website called www.APIGee.com/console allows you to test different APIs without needing to write any program. Just say "what is required" and the "how to do it" part is handled by 'APIGee' itself. Similarly, you can also try <https://developers>.